stardom—Hema Malini, Sridevi, Madhuri Dixit and, more recently, Deepika Padukone. What's noteworthy is that she is an actor star. "All stars eventually play themselves, especially male ones," says Chaubey. "Alia is getting all the love and credibility fundamentally on the basis of her acting. It's wonderful to see that somebody is loved because of what she does on screen and not for who she is."

Alia also has her 'mentor', 'friend' and 'father' Karan Johar to thank. More than half her filmography has been under Johar's Dharma Productions, for whom she has delivered hits like *2 States*, the two *Dulhania* films, *Kapoor & Sons* and *Raazi*. "She is the ultimate, forever favourite," says Johar, who is also directing her in his next film, *Rocky aur Rani Ki Prem Kahani*. "We have never had a girl next door lead the nation as a movie star. She is a quintessential millennial yet she also has the expertise of a chameleon. It's crazy how expansive and versatile her range is." The fondness and admiration are mutual. It's no surprise that a photograph of them together appears in Alia's vanity van alongside those with Ranbir and with friends and family.

BHATT NATURALLY

That Alia would be an actor was well-established since she was two. "She was always an attention-seeker and I say that in the nicest way it can be said," says Shaheen, her sister and best friend, who is five and a half years her senior. "I'd be rolling my eyes because if there were more than three people around, we knew Alia would dance." She made it a ritual to perform before her maternal grandparents every Sunday while they were visiting from London. Ask Alia if she had an epiphany that she would be an actor and she says, "I just knew it, *yaar*."

She faced the camera for the first time when she was all of six. The film was *Sangharsh* [1999], and she landed the role courtesy her 'dimples', which qualified her to play a younger Preity Zinta. By eight, Alia was on the TV show *Jeena Isi Ka Naam Hai*, declaring, "*Actress banoongi* [I will be an actress]". Philosopher and writer U.G. Krishnamurti, on a visit to the Bhatt residence in Juhu, would tell Mahesh his daughter was "going to be a big star".

Krishnamurti wasn't the only one to spot her potential. Bhansali saw it in nine-year-old Alia's "eyes" that he was in the presence of someone "special". She was there to audition for *Black*, and it would be the first time that she met Ranbir. "Ranbir was an over-excited AD [assistant director] with a camera, taking my pictures," she recalls laughingly. Johar spied the same potential in 17-year-old Alia after testing some 400 girls, convinced "there's something about her" after seeing her audition on a laptop. Filmmaker Yash Chopra would step out during the interval of a special screening of Alia's debut, *Student of the Year*, and tell Mahesh, "*Mubarak ho, bachchi star hai* [Congratulations, your daughter is a star]."

Her parents seem amazed at her abilities and accomplishments. "We were not obsessive about the kind of journey our children should chart for themselves," says Mahesh. "For us, they'd grow up and find out what they thirst for." Alia grew up in a 2BHK in Juhu where her mother Soni Razdan kept her and Shaheen insulated from the film industry.



ON RANBIR KAPOOR

"In our relationship, he's the cat, I am the dog. Now, you go figure. Sometimes I wake up in the morning with so much energy and Ranbir is like 'Easy, easy, calm down, breathe.' If there's been an exciting day, he is the one I start re-enacting it to"